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WRITE YOURSELF INTO THE ROOM



*The Personal Brand Writing Guide for People Tired of Sounding
Like Everyone Else*

BY MK PARRISH · \$28

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This book is educational. It does not promise employment, revenue, clients, media coverage, or admission into any particular room. It gives you a sharper way to describe your work so the right people can understand it and decide what to do next.

Examples in this book are illustrative. Some names and business details are fictional or composite examples created to teach the method.

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READ THIS FIRST

This is a working book, not a passive download.

Read it with a decision-maker's eye. Underline what feels uncomfortably true. Translate every example into your own market. Complete the exercises before you rush toward prettier language.

You do not need to become louder. You need words, structure, proof, and conviction. You need to become easier to understand and easier to choose.

A warning before we begin. Personal branding can become a very expensive costume department. People spend months choosing fonts, posting polished thoughts, and designing logos for a position they have never clearly stated. This book starts underneath the costume. It starts with the sentence.

The sentence tells the room what shelf you belong on, what problem you solve, what you have seen, and why your version of the work deserves attention.

Pen up. We are writing you in.

INTRODUCTION: THE ROOM YOU KEEP GETTING LEFT OUT OF

There is a room you want to be in.

A client roster. An investor's shortlist. A curated panel. A byline. A better job. A leadership meeting where your judgment carries weight. A feed where the people you admire actually read your work. A table where the conversation is serious and nobody is waiting for you to prove you deserve a chair.

And somehow, you keep landing just outside the door.

Not because you lack the goods. Not because the people inside are automatically smarter, more talented, more original, or more prepared than you are. Some of them are. Plenty are not.

The difference is that they are easier to read.

They have written themselves in language that travels. Their work can be repeated by someone else. Their value survives a forwarded email, a hurried introduction, a recruiter screen, a podcast pitch, or a ten-second glance at a profile.

Yours may not.

You may be hiding behind the professional dialect. Results-driven. Cross-functional. Strategic storyteller. Passionate about impact. Proven track record. Leveraging insights to drive growth.

The words are not wrong because they are immoral. They are wrong because they are empty. They put you in a category without making you distinct inside it.

That is the cost of sounding like everyone else. People cannot remember you well enough to choose you.

This book is about fixing that with words. Not louder words. Sharper ones.

We will build the language that makes your work legible, your edge visible, and your presence harder to misread. We will cover positioning, proof, bio writing, LinkedIn, voice, content, offers, websites, and the surfaces where your language has to live once you have written it.

This is not a book about becoming a brand instead of a person.

It is about becoming readable as the person you already are.

You do not get into the room by being the loudest. You get in by being the clearest person they have read all week.

CHAPTER 1: WHY YOU SOUND LIKE EVERYONE ELSE

You sound like everyone else because you learned to write from everyone else.

You absorbed the LinkedIn dialect. You read enough profiles, speaker bios, consultant websites, and founder blurbs to internalize the house style of professional self-erasure. Somewhere along the way, "I know what I am doing" became "I use abstract nouns in a calm voice."

The result is copy that sounds acceptable and says almost nothing.

Generic language feels safe because no one can argue with it.

"I help brands grow" is hard to criticize. It is also hard to remember.

"I help second-act founders stop sounding like the watered-down version of themselves" is easier to challenge. It is also easier to hire, invite, recommend, and repeat.

Specificity creates risk because it creates a position. A position can be disagreed with. It can exclude. It can reveal that you have taste, standards, preferences, and a way of seeing the work that not everyone will share.

That is exactly why it works.

Generic writing is not neutral. It is a decision to be forgettable in exchange for feeling protected. It is the language version of standing in the back of the room with your coat still on, ready to leave before anyone notices you were there.

You did not do this because you are weak. Most professional environments reward smoothness. They teach you to sand off the strange, the specific, and the slightly too alive. They call that polish.

Polish without presence is a shine on nothing.

Your job is not to become theatrical.

Your job is to become precise.

The three ways people disappear on the page

They over-category themselves. They stop at the job title. Writer. Strategist. Consultant. Marketing leader. A category helps people orient, but it does not help them choose.

They over-credential themselves. They stack years, degrees, logos, tools, and titles without explaining the transformation their work creates. Proof matters, but proof without interpretation is a resume pile.

They over-soften themselves. They hedge every claim until nothing lands. "I support teams in exploring opportunities for alignment" may be technically accurate. It is also a long way of saying, "I am afraid to state the value."

The fix is not to become obnoxious. The fix is to become undeniable in plain language.

Vagueness is not humility. It is a failure to decide who you are out loud.

The recognition gap

There is often a gap between the quality of your work and the quality of the language around it.

You know the work from the inside. You remember the deadlines, politics, tradeoffs, wrong turns, last-minute repairs, and quiet decisions that saved the result. The reader sees a title and four bullet points.

That gap is where underestimation lives.

The answer is not exaggeration. The answer is interpretation.

Instead of writing, "Managed integrated campaigns," explain what the campaign required you to notice.

Instead of writing, "Led cross-functional teams," name the friction you were hired to resolve.

Instead of writing, "Developed strategy," describe the decision that changed because you were in the room.

Specificity turns experience into meaning.

Exercise: The Blandness Audit

Open your current bio, About page, LinkedIn headline, or speaker introduction. Circle every phrase that could be copied onto someone else's profile without changing a thing.

Look for:

- Industry adjectives such as strategic, innovative, dynamic, and results-driven
- Empty verbs such as drive, leverage, empower, optimize, and elevate
- Context-free claims such as proven track record, deep expertise, and strong communicator
- Identity fog such as multi-passionate, storyteller, builder, creative, and operator
- Softened outcomes such as support, help, guide, collaborate, and facilitate

Now write one question beside every circled phrase.

What do I actually mean?

"Strategic storyteller" might mean, "I turn messy founder thinking into a narrative investors can repeat."

"Strong communicator" might mean, "I can take a room full of people who disagree and leave them with one sentence they all understand."

"Results-driven" might mean, "I care whether the words change behavior, not whether they sound impressive."

The real sentence is usually under the fake one. Dig there.

Field note

When a sentence feels too plain, ask whether it is plain or merely exposed. Many people confuse clarity with vulnerability because clear language leaves fewer places to hide.

That discomfort is useful. It often means the sentence is finally yours.

CHAPTER 2: THE ROOM AUDIT

Before we write you into the room, we need to know which room.

Most people skip this and try to write one universal bio that will work for every possible audience. That is how they end up with a paragraph that reads like it was assembled by committee.

A bio for a recruiter is not the same as a bio for a client. A speaker introduction is not the same as a LinkedIn headline. A founder blurb for investors is not the same as a personal website About section.

Same person. Different room.

The trick is not to become inconsistent. The trick is to know what each room needs to understand first.

The four rooms

The hiring room wants to know whether you can solve the problem attached to the role. It cares about pattern, scope, proof, judgment, and whether you can operate inside real constraints. It does not need your whole soul in paragraph one.

The client room wants to know whether you understand the pain better than they do. It cares about specificity, trust, outcomes, and whether you sound like someone who can hold the work without making it weird.

The authority room wants to know what you believe. Panels, podcasts, bylines, newsletters, and thought-leadership spaces do not need credentials alone. They need a point of view worth placing in front of an audience.

The personal room wants to know why the work matters to you. This is where reinvention, identity, faith, grief, ambition, recovery, motherhood, origin story, or survival can come forward. It still needs structure. Honesty is not the same as sprawl.

You may be writing for more than one room. That is fine. One room still has to lead.

If you try to serve all four at once, your copy will flatten.

What each room is deciding

Every reader is making a decision. They may be deciding whether to interview you, buy from you, trust you, invite you, follow you, remember you, or send your name to someone else.

Clear writing respects that decision.

The hiring room asks, "Can this person handle this level of problem?"

The client room asks, "Do they understand what is expensive, frustrating, or risky about this?"

The authority room asks, "Will this person say something worth hearing?"

The personal room asks, "Do I recognize myself in the way this person sees the world?"

Your copy should answer the room's actual question before it tells the room everything you wish it knew.

Exercise: Choose the primary room

Answer these before you write another sentence.

1. What room am I trying to enter in the next six months?
2. Who is the person inside that room who needs to understand me quickly?

3. What do they currently misunderstand, underestimate, or not know about me?
4. What decision do I want them to make after reading me?
5. What proof would make that decision easier?
6. What part of my story is useful here, and what part is emotional background?
7. What would make the wrong person leave while making the right person lean closer?

This is not cold. It is considerate. Clear writing respects the reader's actual decision.

The sentence that unlocks the room

Every room has a sentence it needs from you.

For the hiring room:

“*I am the person you bring in when [specific problem] needs [specific kind of judgment].*”

For the client room:

“*I help [specific person] solve [specific problem] without [the pain they are tired of].*”

For the authority room:

“*I believe [specific point of view] in a field that usually [default behavior].*

For the personal room:

“*My work is shaped by [lived truth], which is why I care about [specific transformation].*

Do not use these as final copy yet. Use them as diagnostic tools. If you cannot complete the sentence, you are not ready to write the bio. You are still finding the room.

The room map

Create a one-page map for the room you chose.

Write the reader's name or role at the top. Under it, list:

- What they are responsible for
- What they are afraid of getting wrong
- What they are tired of hearing
- What they need to be able to repeat about you
- What evidence they trust
- What next step is reasonable

This map stops you from writing into a mirror. It gives the language a destination.

CHAPTER 3: THE THREE-LAYER POSITIONING FRAMEWORK

Strong personal positioning is not a tagline. It is a stack.

Each layer answers a different question.

1. What am I?
2. Who is this for, and what changes because of me?
3. Why me, and not the other person with the same category label?

Get all three and your writing has a spine. Skip one and you sound like everyone else.

Layer One: The category

This is the plainest possible label for what you do.

Copywriter. Fractional CMO. Career coach. Product designer. Founder. Ghostwriter. Brand strategist. Marketing operator. Therapist. Photographer. Consultant.

Layer One is not where you get clever. It is where you become findable.

The mistake is skipping straight to metaphor. "Word alchemist" does not help me. "Strategic storyteller" only helps if I already know what work you sell. "Brand whisperer" makes me want to close the tab.

The shelf matters. People cannot reach for you if they do not know which shelf you live on.

Keep Layer One boring and true.

Layer Two: The specific

This is where you narrow the category until it becomes useful.

Who exactly do you serve? What problem do you solve? What kind of situation are they in? What outcome are they trying to reach? What do you understand about that situation that other people miss?

Generic:

“
Copywriter for businesses.

Specific:

“
Copywriter for wellness founders who are sick of sounding clinical and want to sound like a human who actually cares.

Generic:

“
Marketing consultant.

Specific:

“
Marketing consultant for founders whose product works, but whose funnel still explains it like a pitch deck.

Generic:

“

Career coach.

Specific:

“

Career coach for women who built impressive lives around survival skills and now want ambition that does not feel like self-abandonment.

Narrowing feels like shrinking the market. It is usually the opposite. The more specific you are, the more the right reader feels recognized.

Recognition is conversion before conversion.

Layer Three: The edge

Your edge is the belief, standard, method, or lived pattern that separates you from everyone else in the same category.

It is not your personality. It is not "I care deeply." It is not "I bring a unique perspective" unless you name the perspective.

Your edge might sound like this:

“

Most brand voice work fails because it decorates instead of deciding. I make brands choose who they are before I make them sound good.

Or:

“
I do not think clarity is about simplifying until the work sounds small. I think clarity is about making complexity survivable.

Or:

“
I help people write professional stories that include the truth without turning the whole page into a confession.

An edge gives people language to repeat about you. It lets someone say, "You need her. She is the one who..." and finish the sentence without opening your resume.

Putting it together

Use this rough formula:

“
I am a [Layer One] for [Layer Two], and I believe [Layer Three].

Example:

“
I am a brand strategist for second-act founders, people building the thing they were too scared to build at twenty-eight, and I believe your story is your strongest asset when you stop burying it under jargon.

Example:

“*I am a ghostwriter for executives whose ideas are sharper than their public voice, and I believe the best thought leadership sounds like a person thinking in real time, not a press release wearing shoes.*”

Example:

“*I am a growth marketer for small teams with real products and messy funnels, and I believe conversion starts with a sentence the customer can repeat.*”

Your version does not have to be cute. It has to be usable.

Five ways to find your edge

The refusal. What do you refuse to do, say, recommend, or normalize in your field?

The correction. What does your industry routinely get wrong?

The pattern. What problem keeps following you across roles, clients, and seasons?

The tradeoff. What do you protect even when it costs speed, applause, or convenience?

The lived lens. What have you experienced that permanently changed the way you see the work?

A strong edge usually contains a tension. Clarity without flattening. Authority without performance. Ambition without self-abandonment. Growth without manipulation. Beauty without decoration for decoration's sake.

Tension creates energy. Energy creates memory.

Exercise: Build the stack

Write five Layer One labels. Pick the plainest.

Write ten possible Layer Two specifics using these prompts:

- Your best-fit person
- Their season
- Their pain
- Their desired outcome
- The default option they are tired of
- The expensive mistake they are trying to avoid
- The identity they are growing into

Now write five edge statements beginning with:

- I believe...
- Most people in my field get this wrong...
- My work is different because...
- I refuse to...
- The thing I know from experience is...

Stack them into three positioning drafts. Read each aloud.

The strongest version will feel a little scary and obviously true.

CHAPTER 4: PROOF IS NOT A PILE OF RECEIPTS

Most people either under-prove or over-prove.

Under-proving sounds like confidence without evidence.

“*I help brands transform their messaging and unlock growth.*”

Over-proving sounds like a resume dumped into a paragraph.

“*With twelve years of experience across SaaS, DTC, media, nonprofits, and enterprise organizations, I have managed cross-functional teams, launched integrated campaigns, built frameworks, led initiatives, and collaborated with stakeholders.*”

The reader drowns before learning why any of it matters.

Good proof is selected. It is interpreted. It is attached to the claim it supports.

The proof ladder

Think of proof in four levels.

Level one: Credential proof. Degrees, titles, logos, certifications, years. Useful, but rarely enough alone.

Level two: Outcome proof. Revenue, audience growth, retention, promotion, launches, conversion, before-and-after movement. Stronger because it shows change.

Level three: Pattern proof. The repeated kind of problem you solve across roles, clients, or seasons. This is where a career begins to look coherent.

Level four: Judgment proof. The decisions you made, the tradeoffs you saw, and the thing you knew to do when the obvious answer was wrong. This is the proof that makes people trust you with higher-stakes work.

Most bios stop at Level One.

Premium positioning lives at Levels Three and Four.

Same proof, better interpretation

Flat:

“*I have ten years of experience in marketing and communications.*”

Better:

“*For ten years, I have been the person teams call when the work is good but the language is not carrying it yet.*”

Flat:

“*Managed multiple successful launches.*”

Better:

“*I have launched offers from messy first draft to paid customer, which means I know the difference between copy that sounds exciting internally and copy a buyer can act on.*”

Flat:

“*Worked with executive teams.*”

Better:

“*I work well with executives because I can translate half-formed strategy into language without making people feel exposed for not having the words yet.*”

The stronger versions do not just state experience. They explain what the experience taught you to see.

Proof has to match the room

A recruiter may care about scale, scope, and progression.

A founder may care that you have seen the exact mess they are in.

A podcast host may care that you can turn experience into a point of view.

A customer may care about what changes after buying.

Do not use every receipt in every room. Use the evidence that reduces the reader's specific risk.

The proof sentence

A useful proof sentence contains three parts.

1. The fact
2. The interpretation
3. The relevance

Example:

“*I helped rebuild a channel program across multiple markets. The useful part was not the number of markets. It was learning how to create one message that local teams could adapt without turning it into five different brands.*”

Example:

“*I have written for founders, executives, and technical teams. That range taught me how to preserve intelligence while removing the language that makes a smart idea feel inaccessible.*”

Example:

“*I influenced more than \$40 million in pipeline across several roles. The number matters, but the pattern matters more. I know how to connect positioning, campaigns, sales behavior, and the actual decision a buyer makes.*”

Exercise: Proof inventory

Create three columns.

Column one: Facts. List everything factual you can prove. Years, roles, clients, industries, metrics, credentials, projects, launches, audiences, awards, publications, responsibilities.

Column two: Patterns. Next to each fact, ask what pattern it shows. Do you repeatedly clarify, build, repair, translate, sell, stabilize, simplify, open doors, or make chaotic things usable?

Column three: Judgment. Ask what you knew to do that someone else might have missed.

That third column is where your best copy lives.

The evidence test

For each major claim in your bio or offer, ask:

- What fact supports this?
- What happened because of it?
- What did I notice that changed the approach?
- Can I say this without revealing confidential information?
- Is the proof recent enough for the room I want now?
- Does the evidence show judgment, not just activity?

Proof should not make the reader admire your storage capacity. It should make the next decision feel safer.

CHAPTER 5: WRITING THE BIO

Your bio is the most-read, least-considered thing you will ever write.

People skim it in seconds and decide whether you are worth more attention. Most bios waste those seconds on adjectives.

Three rules first.

1. Lead with the reader's interest, not your resume. They care what you do for them before they care what you have done.
2. One specific beats ten generals. A concrete detail outperforms a paragraph of "proven track record."
3. Sound like a person. Read it aloud. If you would not say it to a smart friend, cut it.

Template A: The third-person professional bio

Use this for event pages, guest posts, press, speaker introductions, and partner pages.

Structure:

“
*[Name] + [Layer One and Two positioning] + [one proof or pattern]
 + [point of view] + [human detail or current focus].*

Before:

“*Jordan Ellis is a results-oriented marketing professional with over a decade of experience helping organizations achieve their goals through innovative, data-driven strategies.*”

Nothing in that sentence could not be said about ten thousand people.

After:

“*Jordan Ellis helps DTC skincare brands write email flows people actually open, work that has added seven figures to brands you have probably bought from. She believes most email marketing fails because it sells before it earns the right to. Her work sits at the intersection of conversion, restraint, and subject lines with a pulse.*”

Specific. Opinionated. Human. You remember Jordan now.

Template B: The first-person short bio

Use this for your website, newsletter footer, social profiles, and anywhere the reader expects to hear directly from you.

Structure:

“*[What I do, plainly] + [for whom] + [the belief] + [a line of personality or texture].*”

Before:

“
I am a passionate freelance writer dedicated to crafting compelling content that drives engagement and delivers value to clients across various industries.

After:

“
I write the words founders are too close to their own work to find. Mostly for technical people who do extraordinary things and explain them like a tax form. I believe clarity is the highest form of respect. I have never once "circled back" and I never will.

Template C: The one-liner

Use this for bylines, introductions, podcast descriptions, email signatures, and the sentence you say when someone asks what you do.

Structure:

“
I help [specific person] [specific outcome] by or without [edge].

Examples:

- I help underestimated founders sound as formidable as they actually are.
- I help technical teams explain complicated products without sanding off the intelligence.
- I help women in transition write the story that finally fits.
- I help founders turn "I know what I mean" into a page someone can buy from.

The one-liner is not supposed to say everything. It is supposed to earn the next question.

Template D: The long About-page bio

Use this when you have room to create context.

A strong long bio usually moves through six parts.

1. The hook, problem, or misreading
2. The positioning, what you do and for whom
3. The proof, why you can be trusted
4. The point of view, what you believe
5. The story, the lived reason the work matters
6. The invitation, what to do next

Example outline:

“*Most founders do not have a brand problem. They have a language problem.*”

“*I help [specific person] turn the work they already know how to do into copy other people can understand, trust, and buy from.*”

“*My background spans [proof], but the pattern underneath it is simpler. I am usually brought in when the thing is good and the words are not carrying it.*”

“*I believe clarity is not simplification. It is respect. It is the work of making complexity useful without making it small.*”

“*I came to this work because [short origin story], which taught me [relevant lens].*”

“*If you are ready to [outcome], start here.*”

Notice the story does not arrive first. It arrives after the reader understands why it matters.

The seven-second edit

Read only the first two lines of your bio. Ask:

- Do I know what this person does?
- Do I know who it is for?
- Is there a phrase I could repeat to someone else?
- Do I feel a point of view beginning?
- Is there a reason to keep reading?

If the answer is no, do not repair paragraph four. Fix the opening.

Exercise: Write the set

Write all four.

- A 25-word version
- A 50-word version

- A 100-word version
- A long About-page version

Do not make the 25-word version by trimming the long one. Write each for its job.

Then read them aloud and mark every place where your voice becomes formal because you are trying to sound qualified. Rewrite those lines in the language you would use with a smart person you trust.

CHAPTER 6: VOICE, THE THING THAT ACTUALLY DIFFERENTIATES YOU

Two people can have identical positioning and sound nothing alike.

That difference is voice, and it is the one thing a competitor cannot copy off your About page.

Voice is not a collection of adjectives. Warm. Bold. Witty. Premium. Human. Those are aspirations, not instructions.

Voice is built from small, repeatable choices.

Rhythm

Do you run long and rolling, or short and clipped? Do you like a sentence that builds, gathers heat, and lands somewhere the reader did not expect? Or do you like a clean hit?

Neither is better. Unconscious rhythm is the problem. Deliberate rhythm is voice.

A punch lands harder after a longer sentence sets it up.

Like this.

Read your writing aloud. Mark where you naturally pause. That is useful data. Your voice often exists in the places where your spoken rhythm disagrees with the sentence you wrote for approval.

Diction

Your diction is your actual word bank.

Do you say gut or intuition? Work or craft? Client or person? Audience or reader? Strategy or spine? Luxury or relief? Sacred or serious?

Tiny choices create a recognizable atmosphere.

You do not need fancy words. You need chosen words.

Create two lists.

Words I reach for naturally. These are words that appear in your conversations, texts, notes, and unedited drafts.

Words I borrow when I am performing expertise. These are words you use because the industry trained you to use them.

The first list is material. The second list is evidence.

Refusals

Voice is defined by what you refuse to say.

Make a no-fly list.

- Words that make you sound colder than you are
- Words that make you sound softer than you are
- Words that belong to your industry but not your mouth
- Phrases you use when you are hiding
- Phrases you use when you are trying to sound legitimate

Your list might include passionate about, humbled to announce, leverage, empower, impact at scale, thought leader, aligned solutions, authentic self, game-changing, or disrupt.

Some of these words may be useful for someone else. That does not matter. This is your list.

Repetition

Voice becomes recognizable through repeated concerns.

You do not need to invent a new personality every time you write. You need to keep returning to the ideas that are actually yours.

Mine might include reinvention, being misread, precision, voice, the cost of hiding, and the difference between decoration and decision.

Yours might include generosity, discipline, grief, ambition, embodiment, faith, money, motherhood, power, repair, beauty, systems, language, or leadership.

Do not panic when your themes repeat. Repetition is how people learn what to come to you for.

Heat and restraint

Every voice has a natural level of heat.

Some writers name the uncomfortable truth immediately. Others earn it slowly. Some use humor to create permission. Others use tenderness. Some are intimate. Others are exact.

Your job is not to maximize heat. Your job is to calibrate it.

A professional bio may need thirty percent of your full heat. A personal essay may need ninety. A sales page may need more directness and less autobiography. The voice remains yours, but the volume changes with the room.

The voice spectrum

Choose where you naturally sit on each line.

- Direct or exploratory
- Polished or conversational

- Spare or lush
- Warm or cool
- Serious or playful
- Tender or challenging
- Practical or philosophical
- Controlled or confessional

Do not choose what sounds admirable. Choose what is true when you are at your best.

Exercise: Find your native language

Write three hundred unedited words answering:

“

What do I know about my work that I wish more people understood?

Do not polish. Do not perform. Write fast.

Now highlight:

- Three phrases that sound most like you
- Three sentences with actual heat
- Three words you would use in conversation
- One belief you did not realize you had until you wrote it
- One joke, comparison, or image that could only have come from you

Build your voice guide from those lines.

Positioning gets you considered. Voice gets you remembered. You need both, and only one of them cannot be stolen.

CHAPTER 7: LINKEDIN, THE SIDE ENTRANCE

LinkedIn is where many rooms keep a side entrance.

It is not the whole game. It is not your soul. It is not a diary. It is one of the first places people go when deciding whether the version of you they heard about is real.

Most profiles are obituaries for past jobs. They list where you have been in the dead language of HR.

We are going to make yours a living document.

The headshot

Your photo does not need to be glamorous. It needs to look like a person someone could speak to.

Check:

- Is your face clear?
- Do you look approachable, not frozen?
- Is the crop current?
- Does the photo match the room you want to enter?
- Does it still look like the version of you who would arrive at the meeting?

Do not overthink it. A good-enough current photo beats a perfect photo from a version of you that no longer exists.

The banner

The banner is free real estate. Use it.

Options include:

- Your one-liner
- A short positioning statement
- A proof point
- A visual from your brand
- A phrase that names your work
- Your website or primary call to action

Do not leave the default void unless invisibility is the strategy.

The headline

The headline is the highest-leverage line on the page.

Bad:

“
Senior Brand Manager | MBA | Marketing Professional

Better:

“
Brand strategy for founders in their second act | I make overlooked brands impossible to ignore

Bad:

“
Freelance Writer | Content Creator | Storyteller

Better:

“
I write founder stories that sound like a person, not a pitch deck

Bad:

“
Consultant helping businesses grow

Better:

“
Growth strategy for teams whose product works but whose funnel still does not

Use one of these formulas:

“
[Specific work] for [specific person] | [edge or outcome]

Or:

“
I help [specific person] [specific outcome]

Keep it readable. You are not optimizing for keyword soup. You are optimizing for recognition.

The About section

The first two lines matter because people have to click "see more."

Do not start with:

“
I am a seasoned professional...

Start with tension.

“
Most founders can explain their product in a meeting and somehow lose the plot on the homepage.

Or:

“
*You are not being underestimated because you are unimpressive.
You are being underestimated because your words are doing a
terrible job representing you.*

Then move into:

1. What you do
2. Who it is for
3. What you believe
4. Proof

5. How to work with you

End with a clear next step. Visit the site. Read the work. Book the call. Send the email. Do not make the reader invent the next move.

The experience section

Rewrite your current role first. Do not list duties. Interpret the work.

Instead of:

“*Responsible for content strategy, campaign development, stakeholder management, and reporting.*”

Try:

“*Built the content strategy that turned scattered founder ideas into a repeatable publishing system. My job was not just producing assets. It was finding the argument underneath the business and making it visible across every surface.*”

For older roles, you do not need full paragraphs. You need relevance. Keep what supports the room you want now.

The Featured section

The Featured section should function like a proof shelf.

Include two to five items that make your positioning believable.

- A strong article

- A case study
- A portfolio page
- A media appearance
- A product
- A talk
- A lead magnet
- A client result you can share

Do not feature everything. Feature the pieces that teach the reader how to understand you.

Recommendations and social proof

Recommendations are strongest when they describe a pattern, not a personality.

"MK is wonderful to work with" is pleasant.

"MK can listen to a founder explain six different ideas and find the one sentence the market needs" is positioning.

When requesting a recommendation, prompt the person.

Ask:

- What problem did I help solve?
- What did I notice that changed the work?
- What was different after?
- What kind of situation would make you recommend me?

The quarterly audit

Run this every three months.

- Does my headline still match the work I want?
- Does my About section open with tension?

- Is there proof, not just adjectives?
- Did I remove the language of the old room?
- Does the profile sound like me?
- Is there a clear next step?
- Does my Featured section support my current position?
- Would the right person know what to contact me about?

Your profile should keep up with your becoming.

CHAPTER 8: CONTENT THAT PROVES THE POSITION

A bio makes the claim.

Your content proves it.

This is where many people sabotage themselves. They write a strong headline, then publish posts that sound like everyone else. They say they have an edge, then spend six months posting safe generalities.

The room does not need to see who you are once. It needs to see the pattern.

Build content pillars from your positioning

Your content pillars should not be random topics you might enjoy. They should be recurring evidence of your position.

Use five pillars.

Expertise. What do you know cold?

Point of view. What do you believe that the default advice misses?

Proof. Where can you show results, process, before-and-after movement, or decisions?

Story. What lived experiences make your work more textured?

Invitation. How do people work with you, buy from you, hire you, or go deeper?

If you are a brand strategist for second-act founders, your pillars might be:

- Repositioning after a career or life pivot
- Why generic brand voice fails
- Before-and-after copy teardowns
- Personal essays on reinvention and visibility
- Offers, services, and ways to work together

That is enough. You do not need forty-seven content ideas. You need a system of return.

The proof post

Structure:

1. What was broken?
2. What did you notice?
3. What did you change?
4. What happened?
5. What can the reader learn?

Example:

“

The homepage was not bad. That was the problem.

It was clean, polished, and interchangeable with six competitors. The founder kept saying, "I know we are different, but the page does not show it."

We did not start with design. We started with the sentence the company was afraid to say. They were not the affordable option anymore.

Once that changed, every section got sharper. The headline named the premium buyer. The services page stopped apologizing for the price.

The About page stopped sounding like a timeline and started sounding like a point of view.

Conversion improved, but more importantly, the wrong leads stopped showing up.

Sometimes the copy problem is really a permission problem.

That post proves taste, process, and judgment.

The belief post

Structure:

1. State the belief
2. Name the default belief it pushes against
3. Explain why the default fails
4. Give a better way
5. End with a line worth repeating

Example:

“
*Your bio should not make you sound impressive.
It should make you legible.*

Impressive is vague. It reaches for adjectives and hopes the reader fills in the blanks. Legible is specific. It tells the reader what you do, who you do it for, why it matters, and why you are not interchangeable.

The goal is not applause. The goal is accurate recognition.

This is how people begin to associate you with an idea.

The story post

A story post is not a diary entry with a business lesson stapled to the end.

Use this structure:

1. Start inside a moment
2. Show the tension
3. Name what changed
4. Connect the change to the work
5. Leave the reader with a question or recognition

The story earns its place by changing the way the reader understands your judgment.

The invitation post

Do not hide the offer forever.

Structure:

1. Name the person
2. Name the problem

3. Name the transformation
4. Name the offer
5. Give the next step

Example:

“

If your LinkedIn still describes the person you were two jobs ago, that is not a branding problem. It is a misread.

The Rewrite is for people at a turn: founders, executives, career changers, and consultants whose work has outgrown the language around it.

We rebuild the professional story from the truth up. Positioning, bio, headline, About section, and the words you actually need to be read correctly.

If that is the work, book the call.

Selling clearly is not pressure. It is information.

The content matrix

Take your five pillars and cross them with four formats.

- Observation
- How-to
- Before and after
- Story

That gives you twenty useful directions without forcing you to invent a new identity every Monday.

For example, the pillar "proof" can become:

- An observation about why metrics without interpretation feel flat
- A tutorial on building a proof inventory
- A before-and-after bio rewrite
- A story about a decision that changed a launch

Your position creates the content. You do not have to chase the content calendar around the internet.

Exercise: The twelve-post proof set

Write:

- Three belief posts
- Three proof posts
- Two story posts
- Two teaching posts
- Two invitation posts

Schedule them across four weeks.

At the end of the month, ask what people repeated back to you. Repetition is market research. It tells you which sentence is traveling.

CHAPTER 9: THE SURFACES YOU NEED TO REWRITE

Your positioning should not live in one beautiful paragraph and nowhere else.

Once you find the language, distribute it across the surfaces where people meet you.

Consistency does not mean copying the same sentence everywhere. It means the same position survives every format.

Your website

Minimum surfaces:

- Homepage headline
- Homepage subheadline
- About-page opener
- Services or offer page
- Contact page
- Footer bio

Your homepage should answer:

1. Who is this for?
2. What changes because of you?
3. Why should I trust you?
4. What should I do next?

Your About page should not be a chronology. It should be the story that makes your work make sense.

Your services page should name the problem, not simply list the deliverables.

Your contact page should reduce friction. Tell the reader what to contact you about, what happens next, and whether there is a better route for smaller questions.

Your email signature

Tiny, but useful.

Bad:

“
Best, Jordan

Better:

“
Jordan Ellis
Email strategy for DTC brands people actually open
jordanellis.com

The signature should support recognition without becoming a miniature billboard.

Your speaker bio

A speaker bio should make the audience interested in your perspective, not merely certify that you have a job.

Include:

- Your category
- Your audience
- Your point of view
- One proof point
- The angle you bring to the room

A useful speaker bio makes the host's introduction easier and the audience's expectation sharper.

Your media kit

If you want podcasts, panels, press, or guest posts, create:

- A 50-word bio
- A 100-word bio
- A current headshot
- Topics you can speak on
- Sample questions
- Links to previous writing or talks
- Contact information

Your topics should not be vague.

Bad:

“
Branding, marketing, entrepreneurship

Better:

- Why high-performing people undersell themselves on paper
- How to rewrite a professional story after a pivot

- The difference between brand voice and brand decoration
- Why clarity raises your pricing ceiling

Specific topics get booked.

Your checkout or sales page

If you sell anything, your product pages need the same clarity.

For every offer, write:

- Who it is for
- What problem it solves
- What the buyer receives
- What changes after using it
- What it does not include
- What the next step is

Do not make the buyer translate.

A page that says "Unlock your potential" is asking the buyer to do your positioning work for you.

A page that says "Rewrite your LinkedIn so recruiters understand the level you already operate at" has made a decision.

Your introductions

You need three spoken introductions.

The ten-second version. One sentence.

The thirty-second version. Position, proof, and current focus.

The two-minute version. Enough context for a real conversation without turning the other person into a captive audience.

Practice all three aloud. The words should feel like your mouth, not just your keyboard.

The distribution audit

Search your name online. Open every surface a serious reader might find.

Mark each one:

- Current and aligned
- Accurate but weak
- Outdated
- Contradictory
- Missing a next step

Fix the highest-traffic contradiction first.

A beautiful website cannot rescue a LinkedIn profile that tells a different story. A strong bio cannot rescue a sales page that returns to generic language. The room reads the whole system.

CHAPTER 10: BEFORE-AND-AFTER LIBRARY

Sometimes the easiest way to understand stronger writing is to see the weak version beside the better one.

Founder bio

Before:

“*Alex is a visionary founder passionate about building innovative products that help teams collaborate and reach their goals.*”

After:

“*Alex builds the operations software he wished existed when his own team was held together by spreadsheets, Slack threads, and pure adrenaline. His work helps service businesses see what is happening before the missed deadline becomes the client's problem.*”

Why it works:

- It gives the product an origin
- It names the real operational pain
- It replaces "visionary" with a useful point of view
- It creates a picture the reader can remember

Consultant positioning

Before:

“
I help businesses optimize their marketing strategy and drive sustainable growth.

After:

“
I help small B2B teams find the sentence their funnel is missing, then build the campaign around it.

Why it works:

- It names the audience
- It turns a broad service into a specific diagnostic skill
- It suggests a method
- It is easy to repeat

Career pivot bio

Before:

“
I am transitioning from education into UX and am excited to bring my transferable skills into a new field.

After:

“*I spent ten years designing learning experiences for rooms full of distracted humans. Now I design digital products with the same obsession: what does someone need to understand, feel, and do next?*”

Why it works:

- It does not apologize for the pivot
- It translates experience instead of merely labeling it transferable
- It shows a coherent pattern
- It gives the new field a reason to value the old one

Executive LinkedIn opener

Before:

“*I am a seasoned executive with extensive experience leading teams and delivering results in fast-paced environments.*”

After:

“*I usually get called when the team is moving fast, the stakes are high, and the story has started to fracture.*”

Why it works:

- It starts with a situation
- It implies calm under pressure
- It creates curiosity about the pattern

- It sounds like lived experience

Personal brand one-liner

Before:

“
Writer, speaker, and creative strategist.

After:

“
I write about the exact moment a woman stops performing okay and starts telling the truth.

Why it works:

- It names the emotional territory
- It is more memorable than three categories
- It creates a clear expectation for the work
- It makes the right reader feel recognized

Agency homepage

Before:

“
We are a full-service agency delivering innovative solutions that help brands connect, engage, and grow.

After:

“*We rebuild the websites good companies outgrow before the market notices they have outgrown them.*”

Why it works:

- It identifies the moment of need
- It suggests urgency without panic
- It creates a premium problem
- It makes the agency's role easy to understand

Coach offer

Before:

“*Step into your power and create the life you deserve.*”

After:

“*Career strategy for women who have spent years being dependable and are ready to become visible without becoming someone they do not recognize.*”

Why it works:

- It names the person and the tension
- It avoids inspirational fog
- It tells the buyer what kind of transformation is being offered
- It preserves emotional depth without becoming vague

Product description

Before:

“

A comprehensive guide designed to empower entrepreneurs with the tools and insights they need to succeed.

After:

“

A thirty-day workbook for founders who know their offer is good and are tired of rewriting the homepage instead of deciding what the offer actually means.

Why it works:

- It names the format
- It names the stuck behavior
- It names the decision underneath the writing problem
- It creates a clear reason to buy now

Speaker topic

Before:

“

Personal branding for success.

After:

“*Why impressive people become invisible on paper, and how to write the sentence that changes the room.*”

Why it works:

- It contains tension
- It promises a specific idea
- It sounds like a talk, not a category
- It gives the event organizer language to promote

Exercise: Make your own library

Collect ten sentences from your current materials that feel flat.

For each, rewrite it three ways.

1. Make it more specific
2. Make it more human
3. Make it more opinionated

Then choose the version that feels most like you with the lights on.

Keep the before-and-after pairs. They become evidence of your own method and a training set for future writing.

CHAPTER 11: THE 30-DAY REWRITE PLAN

You do not need to fix every surface in one sitting.

You need a sequence.

Week One: Find the position

Day 1: Complete the room audit. Choose the primary room and name the decision you want from it.

Day 2: Build your three-layer positioning stack. Write the category, the specific, and the edge.

Day 3: Write five edge statements. Use the refusal, correction, pattern, tradeoff, and lived-lens prompts.

Day 4: Inventory proof. Separate facts, outcomes, patterns, and judgment.

Day 5: Write the one-liner. Draft ten. Keep the clearest three.

Day 6: Test the one-liner. Send it to someone who knows your work and someone who only partly knows it. Ask what they think you do.

Day 7: Revise. Keep the language people understood. Remove the clever phrase that needed explanation.

Week Two: Write the bio set

Day 8: Write the 25-word bio. Make it useful for introductions and profiles.

Day 9: Write the 50-word bio. Add one proof point and one belief.

Day 10: Write the 100-word bio. Add context without returning to chronology.

Day 11: Write the long About-page version. Use the six-part structure.

Day 12: Read all versions aloud. Mark every sentence that sounds like a brochure.

Day 13: Cut what you would not say to a human. Replace formality with precision, not casual filler.

Day 14: Finalize the set. Save the versions in one document so you stop rewriting from zero every time someone asks for a bio.

Week Three: Rebuild LinkedIn

Day 15: Update the headshot and banner. Make the visual first impression current.

Day 16: Rewrite the headline. Use the specific work, specific person, and edge formula.

Day 17: Draft the About section. Make the first two lines earn the click.

Day 18: Add proof and point of view. Choose evidence for the hiring or client room.

Day 19: Rewrite the current role. Interpret the work instead of listing duties.

Day 20: Trim old roles for relevance. Keep the pattern that supports the next room.

Day 21: Publish the changes. Do not wait for the profile to feel final. It is alive.

Week Four: Prove it in public

Day 22: Write one belief post. State the idea you want associated with your name.

Day 23: Write one proof post. Show how you noticed, decided, and changed the result.

Day 24: Write one story post. Use a lived moment that reveals your judgment.

Day 25: Write one invitation post. Name the offer and the person it is for.

Day 26: Update the website or landing-page headline. Carry the position onto owned space.

Day 27: Update the email signature. Reinforce recognition in small moments.

Day 28: Create the media-kit bio. Add topics, questions, proof, and contact details.

Day 29: Send the new bio to one person who can open a room. Make the work travel.

Day 30: Decide what needs to be rewritten next. Choose the next surface based on traffic and opportunity.

This is how positioning becomes a practice instead of a document.

The weekly maintenance habit

After the thirty days, spend thirty minutes each week maintaining the system.

Ten minutes to capture proof.

Ten minutes to write or refine one point of view.

Ten minutes to update one surface or invitation.

The work stays alive because you keep feeding it evidence.

CHAPTER 12: FROM PAGE TO ROOM

Writing yourself in is not a one-time edit.

It is a posture.

You are going to outgrow this language eventually. That is not a failure. It is evidence that the work is alive.

The bio you write this year should feel a little small next year if you are doing the thing. The point is not to find the final version. The point is to stop letting an old or generic version speak for you when the real one is available.

Say the specific thing in public, repeatedly

The point of view from Layer Three is not only for your bio. It belongs in your posts, talks, replies, interviews, sales pages, and conversations.

Repeat your themes until people associate them with your name.

That association is part of being in the room.

Let the wrong people leave

Sharp positioning will cost you the people who were never going to hire, read, recommend, or champion you.

Good.

They were taking up space the right people could not fill.

Precision costs you the indifferent and earns you the devoted.

Update as you become

The page should always be slightly ahead of who you were and exactly level with who you are becoming.

Do not inflate the future. Do not archive yourself in the past. Write from the honest edge of the present.

Practice being introduced

A written position becomes real when someone else says it aloud.

Ask a trusted person to introduce you using your new bio. Listen for what feels true, what feels too polished, and what creates energy in the room.

Then practice introducing yourself without apologizing, over-explaining, or rushing toward a joke that makes the claim smaller.

The words are not only copy. They are rehearsal for visibility.

The room is relational

No sentence replaces the work. No headline replaces generosity. No bio replaces showing up, following through, and becoming someone people trust when the stakes are real.

The language has one job. It helps the right people see what is already there.

Once they see it, your behavior has to confirm it.

That is where a personal brand becomes a reputation.

The room was never locked. You had not written the sentence that opened it yet.

Now you have.

Walk in.

BONUS TOOLKIT

Fifty phrases to question before you publish

These phrases are not universally forbidden. They are alarms. When one appears, ask whether you can say something more specific.

1. Results-driven
2. Passionate about
3. Proven track record
4. Strategic thinker
5. Innovative solutions
6. Dynamic leader
7. Cross-functional
8. Value-added
9. Best-in-class
0. Thought leader
1. Leverage
2. Optimize
3. Empower
4. Elevate
5. Drive impact
6. At scale
7. Authentic self
8. Unique perspective
9. Seasoned professional
0. Various industries
1. Diverse background

- 2. Strong communicator
- 3. Team player
- 4. Fast-paced environment
- 5. Deliver results
- 6. Unlock potential
- 7. Reach your goals
- 3. Transform your life
- 7. Tailored solutions
- 3. Holistic approach
- 1. End-to-end
- 2. Full-service
- 3. Data-driven
- 4. Customer-centric
- 5. Growth mindset
- 6. Storyteller
- 7. Multi-passionate
- 3. Visionary
- 7. Disruptive
- 3. Game-changing
- 1. Leading-edge
- 2. Mission-driven
- 3. Purpose-led
- 4. Collaborative leader
- 5. Extensive experience
- 6. Deep expertise
- 7. Trusted partner
- 3. Meaningful impact
- 7. Create value
- 3. Help people thrive

For each phrase you keep, attach it to evidence.

Do not say "trusted partner." Show the decision someone trusted you to make.

Do not say "innovative." Name what you did differently.

Do not say "impact." Name what moved.

Twenty-five prompts for sharper positioning

1. What do people call me when the obvious title is not enough?
2. What problem keeps following me across jobs or clients?
3. What am I unusually calm around?
4. What do I notice before other people do?
5. What can I explain without making the reader feel stupid?
6. What kind of mess do I know how to enter?
7. What do people thank me for that is not in my job description?
8. What do I refuse to make smaller?
9. What industry phrase makes me roll my eyes?
10. What would I teach if I could only teach one idea for a year?
11. Which result am I proud of, and what decision created it?
12. What part of my background looks unrelated until I explain the pattern?
13. What does the right client already know before hiring me?
14. What is the wrong client still hoping for?
15. What do I make easier to decide?
16. What kind of person feels immediately understood by my work?
17. What am I willing to lose by becoming more specific?
18. What sentence would a former colleague use to recommend me?
19. What do I believe that my industry rewards people for avoiding?
20. What have I survived, repaired, built, or learned that changed my judgment?
21. What do I want to be known for five introductions from now?

2. What proof would make that association credible?
3. What would my bio say if it did not need to impress anyone?
4. What would it say if it had to earn a decision in ten seconds?
5. What is the clearest true sentence I am still afraid to publish?

The final self-edit checklist

Before you publish any professional page, ask:

- Is the primary room clear?
- Is the category plain enough to understand?
- Is the audience specific enough to recognize itself?
- Is there an edge or point of view?
- Is the proof attached to a claim?
- Is there at least one phrase only I would say this way?
- Did I remove language that belongs to the old room?
- Does the first line create a reason to continue?
- Can another person repeat what I do?
- Is the next step obvious?
- Does it sound like me when read aloud?
- Is every sentence doing a job?

If the copy is polished but forgettable, return to the position.

If the position is sharp but the copy sounds borrowed, return to the voice.

If the voice is vivid but the reader does not know what to do, return to the room.

KEEP GOING

Positioning is the start. Voice is the depth.

If this book stirred something larger, a sense that the self you are positioning is itself mid-rewrite, keep following that thread. The work of becoming visible often exposes the work of becoming.

More writing, tools, and ways to work together are available at mkparrish.com.

You were always qualified for the room.

Now you are legible.

That was the missing part.

MK Parrish

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

MK Parrish is a marketing strategist, writer, and growth operator who helps people and companies close the gap between the quality of their work and the language around it. Her work spans positioning, websites, demand generation, personal brand writing, and the difficult business of becoming accurately visible.

She writes about reinvention, voice, ambition, being misread, and the moment an old story stops fitting.

Learn more at mkparrish.com.

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